U.S. Equity-Linked Strategies

Storm Clouds Gather Over Neo-Clouds

Neo-cloud stress is biting hardest in equities, while options signal persistent downside demand. Contagion remains contained, with hyperscalers, broader Tech & Growth style largely insulated; discounted convertibles retain yield, downside support, and recovery participation.

Neo-cloud credit has repriced sharply as investors question the sustainability of debt-funded AI infrastructure, with CoreWeave yields approaching 15% and OAS and CDS widening materially. Yet healthy contracting, rising backlog, and September's convertible issuance suggest fundamentals remain resilient despite recent price action.

Equities are showing signs of even more pain. CoreWeave, Galaxy Digital, and Cipher Digital fell 30%, 31%, and 44%, respectively, from the end of September through October 19, while the S&P 500 rose by 0.5%. Stocks have also responded asymmetrically to credit: widening spreads prompt outsized declines, while tightening provides limited relief, underscoring skepticism around the neo-cloud business model's durability.

Option dynamics point to positioning being decisively defensive. Spreads between short-dated implied and realized volatilities have risen toward the 90th percentile of their one-year ranges, while steeper skew and higher put-to-call open interest signal demand for downside protection. Crowded bearishness nevertheless creates scope for a convex rebound if shorts monetize or the AI narrative around neo-clouds stabilizes.

While looking for signs of contagion, we note that spillovers remain contained for now. Hyperscaler CDS and valuations have largely held up, with Oracle the notable credit exception, while de-rating has centered on neo-clouds and data-center suppliers, and broader Tech and Growth style valuations have stayed stable. Hyperscalers' stronger balance sheets, free cash flow, and ability to absorb displaced compute demand support continued differentiation.

CoreWeave converts have also repriced materially, trading near 72–83 with 6.1–7.6% yields and 75–83% delta. The converts provide yield, discounted bond value and meaningful equity sensitivity, although the securities remain unsecured and subordinated to an expanding secured-financing stack.

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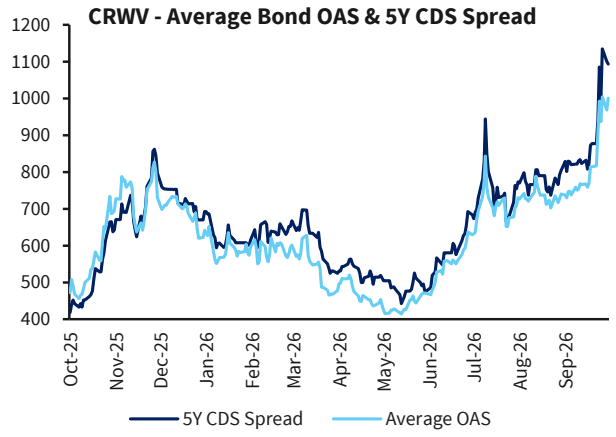
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A view of the neo-cloud turmoil across the capital structure

Investors are increasingly questioning the sustainability of the debt-fueled buildout underpinning the neo-cloud model. Those concerns have come to a head in recent days, with heavy selling across neo-cloud credit and CoreWeave yields surging toward 15%. The move has taken place against a broader backdrop of concerns around AI infrastructure spending, although Barclays credit analysts believe CoreWeave's recent weakness has also been amplified by hedge-fund de-risking and unfavorable press reports (see In the Eye of the AI Storm, 15-Oct-26). Importantly, the fundamental picture appears more resilient than recent price action would suggest, when seen through the lens of the continued supply/demand imbalance for AI infrastructure, significantly improving pricing environment, long-term take-or-pay contracts underpinning many customer deployments and the continued disciplined approach to capacity expansion that leading providers are taking (see rAImo's AI Newsletter #131: Taking Stock Post the AI Infrastructure Rout, 20-Oct-26).

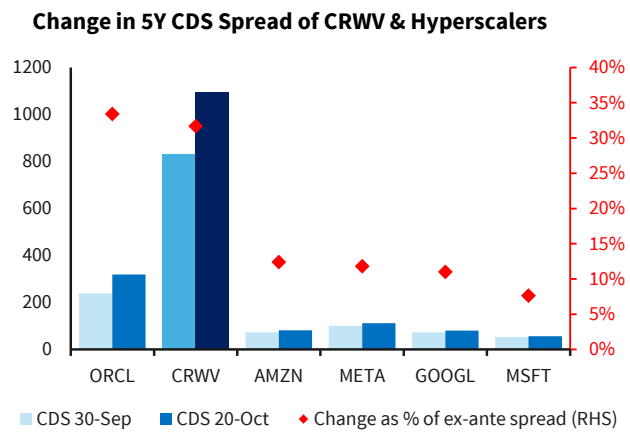
CoreWeave's September convertible issuance ($4.2 billion) also reduced its near-term need to tap equity markets, limiting one potential source of additional supply. Barclays macro strategists have also cautioned against extrapolating the neo-cloud turmoil into implications for the broader AI capex cycle, a la the SVB episode of 2023 (see SVB Redux? 19-Oct-26). Against this backdrop, we take stock of how the recent reassessment of neo-cloud risk has propagated across the capital structure. The clearest signal has come from credit, option-adjusted spreads (OAS) on CoreWeave's bonds (both HY & convertible bonds) have skyrocketed, as have credit default swap spreads on them.

FIGURE 1. Option-adjusted spreads and CDS spreads on CRWV's HY bonds have skyrocketed



Source: Barclays Research

FIGURE 2. ORCL is the only hyperscaler that saw its spread widen as much as CRWV (proportionally)



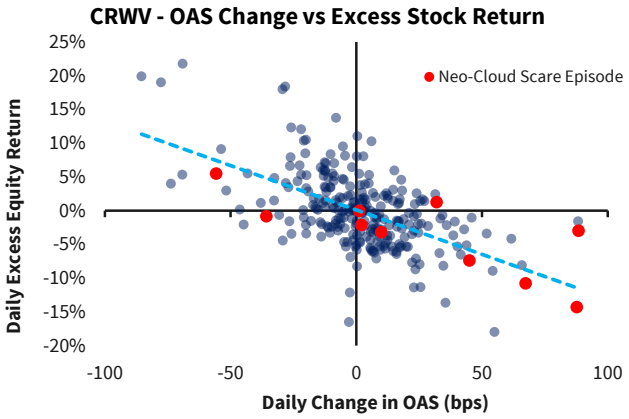
Source: Barclays Research

Just as notable is where the stress has not spread. Despite the wider concerns around AI capex and financing, the deterioration in credit has remained largely confined to the neo-cloud complex, with CDS spreads for most hyperscalers little changed. Oracle stands out as the main exception, with its five-year CDS widening by 80bp, proportionally as large a change as CoreWeave's. This matters: thus far, credit markets appear to be differentiating between the leveraged balance sheets funding the neo-cloud buildout and the much larger platforms financing AI investment from more established businesses with healthier balance sheets.

Signs of stress in equities and options

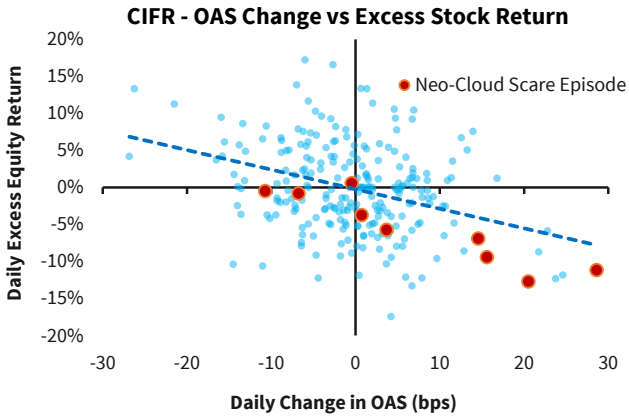
Equities, however, have delivered an even more emphatic verdict. Neo-cloud stocks have experienced drawdowns of more than 30% month-to-date, with CoreWeave, Galaxy Digital, and Cipher Digital down 30%, 31%, and 44%, respectively, through October 19, while the S&P 500 rose by 0.5% during the same period. More interestingly, the relationship between equity and credit has become increasingly asymmetric. Since October 7, neo-cloud equities have tended to overreact to widening credit spreads on the downside while underreacting when spreads tighten. In other words, improvements in credit risk pricing have provided relatively little relief to stocks, while signs of deterioration have been punished aggressively. That asymmetry suggests that concerns around the durability of the neo-cloud model are being expressed most acutely through equities.

FIGURE 3. CoreWeave's stock has overreacted on the downside and underreacted on the upside compared to credit spread moves...



Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

FIGURE 4. ...a pattern that has also been observed in the case of Cipher Digital

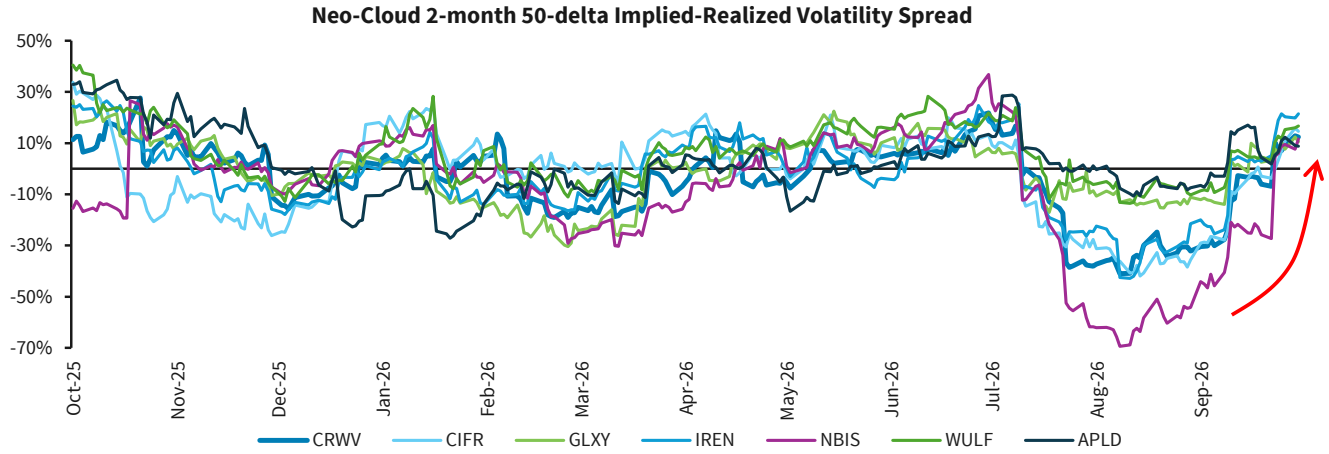


Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

Options markets reinforce the same message. The gap between short-dated implied and realized volatility across several major neo-cloud names has surged toward the 90th percentile of its one-year range. Taken together, the signals across credit, equities, and options point to a meaningful reassessment of the debt-funded AI infrastructure trade. Moreover, for most neo-clouds, implied volatility skew has steepened, and put open interest has risen in relation to call open interest, suggesting more demand for the downside than upside. The two exceptions are Cipher Digital and Galaxy Digital, for which there appears to be increased demand for the upside.

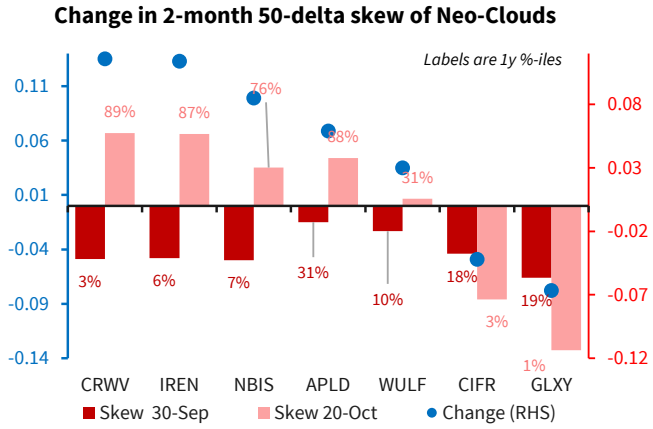
Taken together, the picture we get is one of a decidedly bearish positioning in neo-clouds. Any monetization of shorts or relief in the AI narrative could, as such, trigger a convex recovery in stocks.

FIGURE 5. Short-dated implied volatility surged compared to realized volatility amid fears around neo-cloud financing, with the implied-realized volatility spread rising to nearly the 90th percentile vs the last year



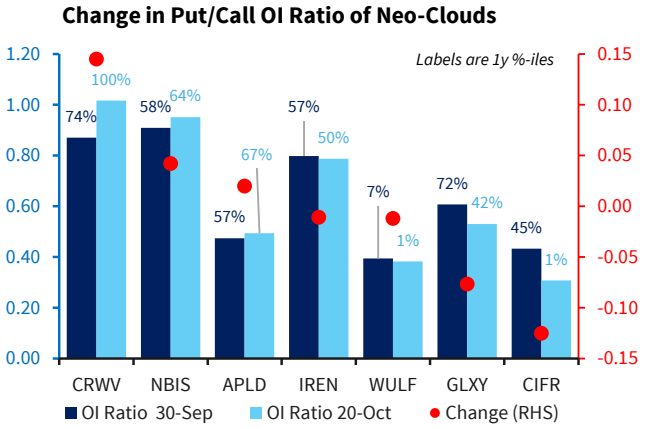
Source: Barclays Derivatives Research

FIGURE 6. Skew has sharply steepened for most neo-clouds, except CIFR & GLXY, where they have inverted



Source: OptionMetrics, Barclays Derivatives Research

FIGURE 7. Put /Call Open Interest Ratio has risen for most neo-clouds, but declined for CIFR & GLXY



Source: OptionMetrics, Barclays Derivatives Research

Are there signs of contagion in stocks?

With what we've seen across the capital structure of neo-clouds, a natural next question would be: what will be the next shoe to drop? Or is this going to be well contained? We look for signs in what has already transpired.

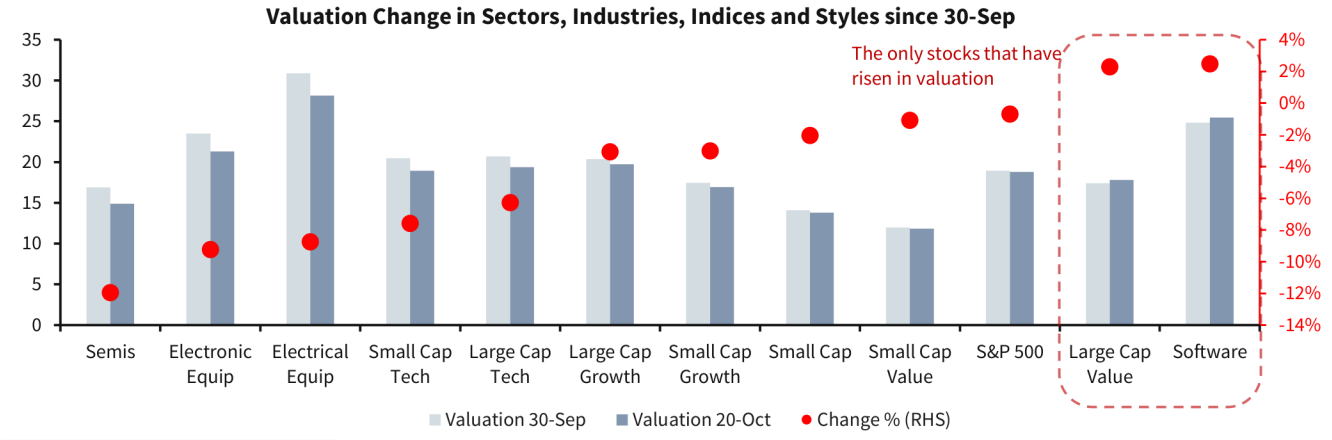
Looking at valuations (Figure 8), we note that unsurprisingly, the stocks that have suffered the sharpest de-rating are the ones that supply the ingredients that make up the data centers: semiconductors, electronic equipment, and electrical equipment. Thus far into October, multiples have declined by around 10%. Broadening the lens, the fallout appears to be well contained for now, as while broader Tech and the Growth style (large and small) have been affected, their de-rating has been comparatively milder. On other hand, Software and Large Cap Value appear to be the only styles so far that have improved their valuations (for context, we have argued in the past that Value acts as an 'anti-AI' style, or in other words, a hedge against periodic scare episodes in the AI narrative).

An important dynamic that should be noted is that at the end of the day, the market for compute is somewhat commoditized, and as such, many of the units of compute the neo-

clouds fail to provide are for the hyperscalers to supply. Therefore, it is not surprising that neo-clouds would not be highly correlated with hyperscalers in terms of price action, and the paths their valuations take would diverge, especially as investors grow concerned about the sustainability of their debt-fueled growth.

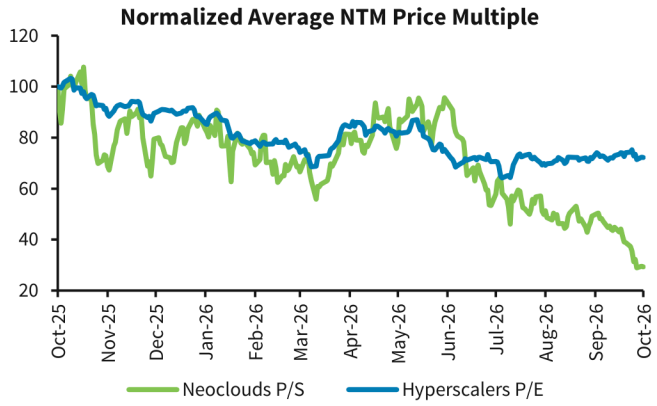
Indeed, we observe that in recent months, and especially over the last couple of weeks, neo-cloud valuations have severely de-rated, while hyperscaler multiples have held up quite well (Figure 9). Moreover, while neo-cloud stock correlations hover around 70%-80% given their exposure to the AI compute factor, the correlation of this cohort to hyperscalers has been low, and started trending even lower in 2H26 (Figure 10). This divergence accelerated as the interest rate surge has forced investors to take a hard look at the economics of neo-cloud financing, while hyperscalers still get to use their considerable cash flows to aid in their buildouts.

FIGURE 8. Looking across all of equities, we note that Software and Large Cap Value have seen their valuations improve, while semis and electronic & electrical equipment manufacturers have de-rated the most



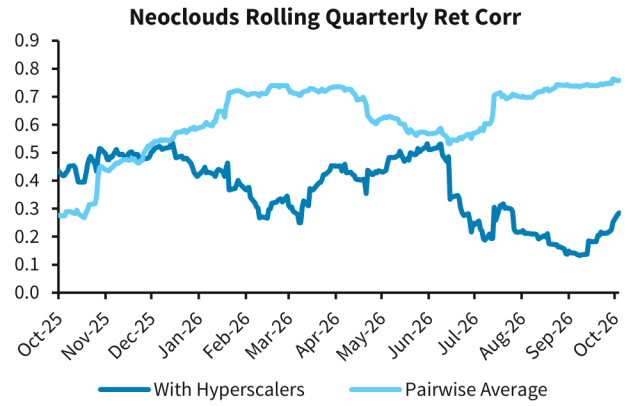
Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

FIGURE 9. The de-rating in neo-cloud valuation has been far more severe than that in hyperscalers



Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

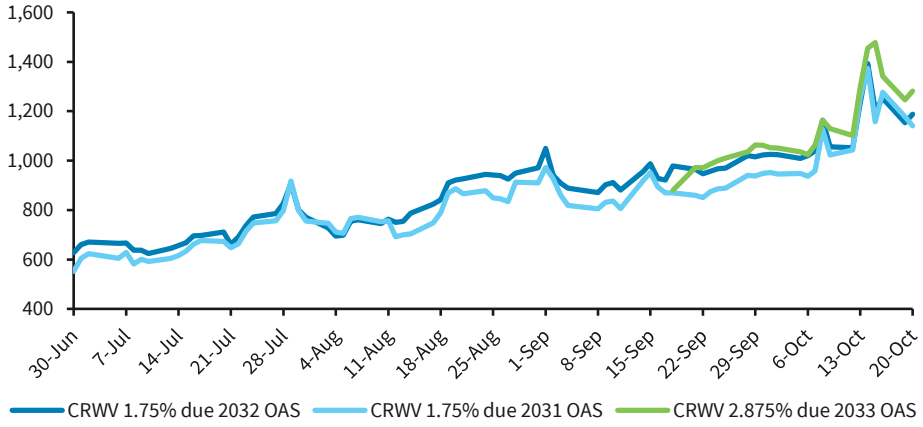
FIGURE 10. While correlations among neo-clouds are extremely high, this cohort has remained little correlated with hyperscalers



Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

Assessing relative value in CoreWeave converts

FIGURE 11. CRWV convertible bond OAS have expanded materially



Source: Barclays Research, Bloomberg

Following the recent selloff, CRWV converts have repriced materially alongside moves in both credit and equity. As shown above, CRWV convertible OAS has widened materially, consistent with the broader repricing in AI infrastructure credit. At the same time, the converts now trade at roughly 72–83, with YTMs of ~6.1-7.6%, while retaining meaningful equity participation through ~75–83% delta. This combination reflects both discounted bond values and continued sensitivity to potential moves in CRWV equity and/or credit.

FIGURE 12. On a relative basis, CRWV converts have repriced materially

Name	Size ($mn)	ISIN	Issue Date	Quality	Price	Cpn (%)	YTP/M (%)	Delta (%)	Prem (%)	OAS as of 9/30 (bp)	OAS as of 10/20 (bp)	OAS Chg (bp)
CoreWeave, Inc. 1.75% 2031	2,588	US21873SAD09	9-Dec-25	High Yield	79.3	1.75	6.58	75.9	37.6	948	1141	193
Coreweave Inc 1.75% 2032	4,000	US21873SAH13	10-Apr-26	Not Rated	72.4	1.75	7.60	78.2	39.4	1023	1188	165
CoreWeave, Inc. 2.875% 2033	4,200	US21873SAL25	18-Sep-26	Not Rated	83.1	2.875	6.08	83.19	30.9	1062	1282	220
Total	10,788			Average	78.3	2.125	6.75	79.10	36.0	1011	1204	193

Note: pricing as of 10/20/2026
Source: Barclays Research, Bloomberg

Relative to straight debt, the converts offer embedded equity optionality alongside credit exposure; relative to owning CRWV equity outright, the converts also have a discounted bond price and yield. The converts remain senior unsecured and sit behind CRWV's secured financing with respect to pledged collateral, an increasingly relevant consideration as the company's secured funding stack expands.

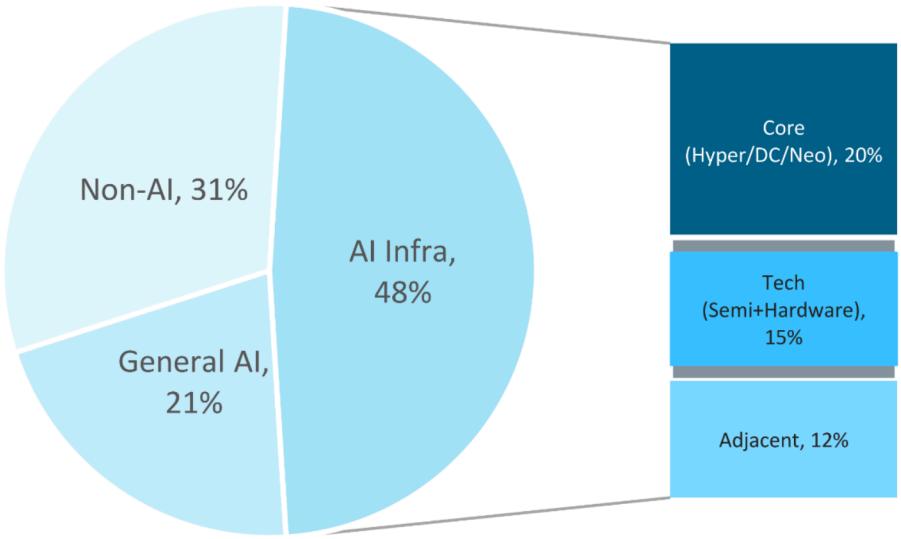
AI Infra Convert Financing Beyond the Storm

Jack Leung BCI, US

Record Issuance, Credit Repricing and the Next Phase of AI Infrastructure Financing

AI infrastructure remains a significant driver of capital demand, but recent credit market repricing has brought greater scrutiny to the cost and sustainability of financing its expansion. Record convert issuance has supported the rapid buildout of neoclouds, datacenters, and GPU infrastructure, while the recent selloff has raised questions about whether contracted AI demand can translate into sufficient cash flow to support growing financing obligations. Convertible markets offer a distinctive perspective on these risks, as widening Hyperscaler, Datacenter, and Neocloud ("HDN") credit spreads and declining implied volatility highlight pressure on both credit valuations and embedded equity optionality. Meanwhile, the emergence of large-scale GPU-backed and project-level financing introduces additional considerations around collateral protection and creditor seniority. These developments extend beyond convertible valuations, with potential implications for broader equity markets, upcoming earnings, and the AI financing outlook for 2027.

FIGURE 13. AI Infrastructure's Growing Convertible Footprint



Note: US convert universe by market value; please visit The AI Converts Complex for methodology and details
Source: Barclays Research, Bloomberg

Can AI Sustain Its Record Convert Issuance Boom?

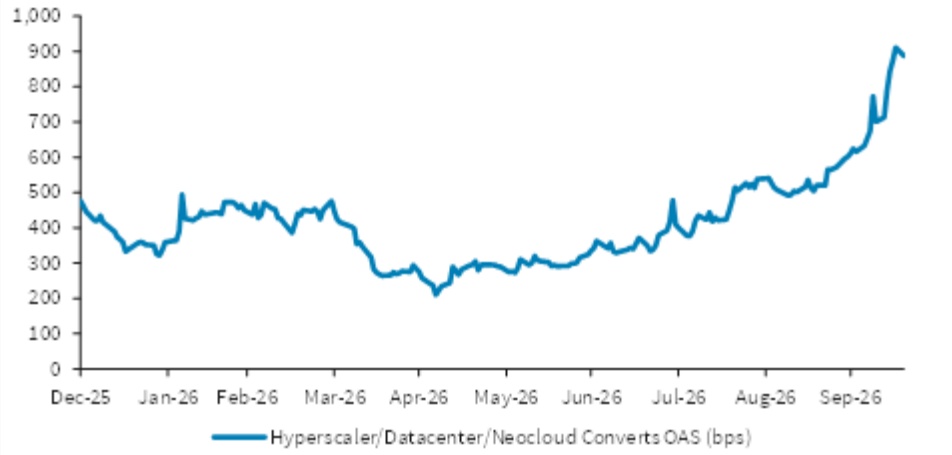
AI infrastructure has emerged as a major driver of record U.S. convertible issuance. Total issuance reached approximately $137bn through October 21, surpassing the previous full-year record of roughly $121bn in 2025. Recent transactions from Nebius (NBIS) and CoreWeave (CRWV), totaling $5.75bn and $4.2bn, respectively, contributed ~$10bn, or more than 7% of 2026 issuance to date. Of the YTD record convert issuance, ~17% ($23.5 billion) is from neo-clouds and data Centers. Beyond core neo-cloud operators, AI exposure extends across semiconductor suppliers, datacenter developers, and related infrastructure businesses. Under our broader classification, AI infrastructure and associated companies account for approximately 48% of the convertible universe by market value, underscoring the asset class's growing exposure to AI-related financing and investment cycles.

Looking toward year-end and 2027, substantial capital requirements should continue to support convertible financing, although issuance conditions may become increasingly selective. Weaker underlying equities, wider credit spreads, and the market's ability to absorb record supply could influence issuance timing, pricing and conversion premiums. The key question is whether the sector's financing needs can sustain more convert issuance momentum as investors become more discerning about credit quality and capital structures. In our view, the pricing, structural flexibility, liability and dilution management avenues, and buyer base mix (arbitrage, long only, and opportunistic) in the convert market should allow for a clearing price for continued issuance (up to a point).

HDN Credit Spreads Widen as Equity Optionality Weakens

Recent weakness across hyperscaler, datacenter, and neocloud (HDN) convertibles highlights a pronounced repricing of credit risk and embedded equity optionality. Between September 25 and October 20, market-value-weighted HDN option-adjusted spreads (OAS) widened 317bp, from 571bp to 888bp, while convertible-implied volatility declined from 62.6% to 55.7%. HDN convertible market value also contracted 14.2%, from $81.6bn to $70.0bn, reflecting a significant reduction in the segment's market footprint.

FIGURE 14. Hyperscaler, Datacenter and Neocloud Convert Credit Spreads Widen



Note: Bonds only with market value at least $250mn or more; excluding mandatories and non-US issuers
Source: Barclays Research, Bloomberg

Earnings Put AI Financing Sustainability to the Test

With 3Q26 earnings under way, the focus is shifting from AI demand growth toward the cash flows and financing required to sustain it. Across the 21 HDN convert issuers, investors should look beyond headline earnings surprises toward backlog conversion, GPU utilization, capital expenditure, funding costs, and liquidity.

FIGURE 15. AI's Funding Gap: Can Cash Generation Keep Pace With Capex?

Issuer group	Representative names	Key earnings questions
Hyperscalers & cloud	MSFT, GOOGL, ORCL, DOCN	Are AI capex commitments supported by cloud growth, improving utilization and investment returns?
Neocloud & GPU operators	CRWV, NBIS, IREN, SHAZ, WYFI, BTBT	How rapidly is backlog converting into revenue and cash flow? How much additional financing is required?
Datacenter infrastructure	CORZ, WULF, CIFR, APLD, GLXY, KEEL, FRMI	Are contracted MW being delivered on schedule, and are project economics sufficient to service debt?
Mining-to-AI transition	MARA, RIOT, CLSK, BTDR	Can existing mining cash flows and balance-sheet resources fund AI infrastructure expansion?ash flows and balance-sheet resources fund AI infrastructure expansion?

Note: Illustrate key 3Q26 earnings questions for the HDN convert issuers
Source: Barclays Research

The distinction between contracted demand and realized cash flow is becoming increasingly important. Strong bookings may provide limited reassurance if deployment delays, rising interest expenses and additional borrowing requirements outpace revenue generation. For convertible investors, earnings and management guidance could help distinguish temporary market dislocations from fundamental credit deterioration, particularly as issuers outline 2027 capex commitments, project milestones, and financing plans. The key differentiator will be which companies can translate AI demand into sustainable cash flows without compromising balance-sheet flexibility or unsecured creditor protection.

Could AI Funding Pressure Spur Financial Engineering in 2027?

Tighter financing conditions could reshape how AI infrastructure issuers access capital. Beyond traditional unsecured convertibles, CRWV, IREN, and NBIS have independently arranged substantial GPU-backed financing, while HUT has tapped secured project bonds to fund datacenter expansion. Although these facilities were not issued as part of the convertible transactions, they illustrate the increasingly varied financing structures supporting AI infrastructure growth. For unsecured convertible investors, additional secured borrowing introduces important considerations around collateral encumbrance, structural subordination, and recovery values, even as the proceeds may support future cash generation.

FIGURE 16. Secured AI Financing Introduces New Considerations for Convertible Creditors

Issuer	Secured financing	Size ($bn)	Date	Collateral / structure	Convertible implications
CRWV	DDTL 4.0 delayed-draw term loan	8.5	Mar-2026	Secured by the assets behind the customer contracts and pledged contracted cash flows; DDTL 4.0 classified as non-recourse debt ($2.837bn drawn at Q2-26).	Converts are senior unsecured; no claim on pledged collateral, and they rank behind a broader secured stack (DDTLs, secured revolver).
IREN	GPU financing: ~$1.5bn secured DDTL + $2.1bn secured USPP notes	3.6	May-2026	Issued by financing SPV (IE US Hardware 3, LLC) with a shared security package; non-recourse except limited guarantees from IREN Limited.	Converts are senior unsecured, effectively subordinated to secured debt to the extent of collateral value and structurally subordinated to subsidiary debt.
NBIS	Senior secured facility (first secured debt), SOFR+2.50%, matures 31-Oct-2030	0.775	10-Jul-2026	Subsidiary borrowers (Nebius Compute II LLC / Oy); secured by deployed GPUs, contracted cash flows and the borrowers' shares; limited parent support incl. non-recourse bad-acts guaranty; 1.15x DSCR covenant.	Converts are senior unsecured; they rank behind the subsidiary's secured lenders on the pledged assets.
HUT	Project-level senior secured notes: River Bend $3.25bn (6.192%, 2042) + Beacon Point $4.25bn (6.129%, 2042)	7.5	Apr-2026 / 9-Jun-2026	Ring-fenced campus entities; secured solely by project assets; debt service from contracted lease cash flows; non-recourse to Hut 8 Corp.	No convert outstanding since Coatue note converted (May-2026); parent-level $1.07bn senior secured revolver closed 24-Sep-2026.

Source: Barclays Research, Company Disclosure

Looking ahead, sustained funding pressure could encourage more bespoke convertible structures, including secured or junior-lien instruments. Historical precedents exist, although largely in private or distressed settings. CoreWeave issued up to $50mn of senior secured convertible notes in 2021, ahead of its IPO, while Core Scientific issued $260mn of third-lien secured converts under its 2024 reorganization plan. The latter converted into equity in July 2024, followed by a separate senior unsecured convertible issuance. While these precedents demonstrate structural feasibility, broader adoption could complicate valuation, reduce standardization, and fragment secondary-market liquidity. For convertible investors, the 2027 outlook may require looking beyond the availability and cost of capital to how evolving financing structures affect collateral coverage, creditor seniority, and downside recovery prospects.

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Materially Mentioned Stocks (Ticker, Date, Price)
CoreWeave, Inc (CRWV, 21-Oct-2026, USD 61.82), Equal Weight/Positive, CD/CE/D/FA/J/L

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Overweight - The stock is expected to outperform the unweighted expected total return of the industry coverage universe over a 12-month investment horizon.

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Braze Inc. (BRZE)	CCC Intelligent Solutions (CCC)	Check Point Software Technologies Ltd. (CHKP)
Cloudflare, Inc. (NET)	Commerce (CMRC)	CoreWeave, Inc (CRWV)
CrowdStrike Holdings, Inc (CRWD)	Datadog, Inc. (DDOG)	Descartes Systems Group (DSGX)
DigitalOcean (DOCN)	Dynatrace, Inc. (DT)	Elastic N.V. (ESTC)
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HubSpot, Inc. (HUBS)	IBM Corp. (IBM)	Intapp, Inc. (INTA)
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Microsoft Corp. (MSFT)	monday.com Ltd (MNDY)	MongoDB, Inc. (MDB)
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OpenText Corp. (OTEX)	Oracle Corp. (ORCL)	Palo Alto Networks (PANW)
Paycom (PAYC)	Paylocity Holding Corp (PCTY)	Pegasystems, Inc. (PEGA)
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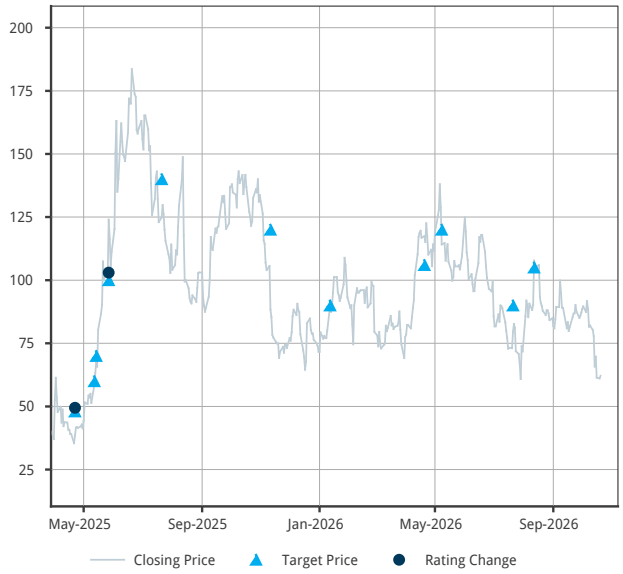
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CoreWeave, Inc (CRWV / CRWV)

Stock Rating: **EQUAL WEIGHT**
Industry View: **POSITIVE**
Closing Price: **USD 61.82** (21-Oct-2026)

Rating and Price Target Chart (as of 21-Oct-2026)



Source: LSEG Data & Analytics, Bloomberg, Barclays Research
Link to Barclays Live for interactive charting

Publication Date	Closing Price*	Rating	Adjusted Price Target	Currency
12-Aug-2026	90.32		105.00	USD
21-Jul-2026	73.06		90.00	USD
08-May-2026	128.84		120.00	USD
20-Apr-2026	116.85		106.00	USD
12-Jan-2026	80.14		90.00	USD
11-Nov-2025	105.61		120.00	USD
21-Jul-2025	123.02		140.00	USD
27-May-2025	100.16	Equal Weight	100.00	USD
14-May-2025	67.46		70.00	USD
12-May-2025	51.37		60.00	USD
22-Apr-2025	35.42	Overweight	48.00	USD

Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

*This is the closing price referenced in the publication, which may not be the last available closing price at the time of publication.

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Valuation Methodology: We apply a ~33x CY27E EV/EBIT and our CY27E EBIT estimate of ~$4.19bn to arrive at our PT of $105. The multiple we apply reflects strong RPO growth and higher sentiment levels for AI infrastructure software peers.

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